

Wonder Ware

A photo studio grows into an image processing software firm and helps India beat a global ban



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SOJITRA (STANDING ON THE LEFT) WITH SONI

By Uday Mahurkar

As an 18-year-old he ran away from his house in Dhoraji, Gujarat, to Mumbai and found work at a colour print studio. He stayed there for 10 years, mopping floors apart from work and studies. A fast learner, he soon established his own colour print studio in Ahmedabad, eventually turning it into a top class software development company. Today, Ramesh Sojitra, 44, has come up with a mapping software described as “revolutionary” by none other than former Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) chairman R. Madhavan Nair. The software is not only a big help to the Indian armed forces but is also making the task of governance, by mapping India, easier and cheaper.

The ban imposed by the developed world on India following the Pokhran blasts left the country stranded when it came to analysing data recovered from satellites. India didn't have the software for analysing data from its own satellites, and the developed countries refused to supply it. It was then that ISRO decided to invite tenders from Indian software companies and it was Sojitra's Scanpoint Geomatics Ltd (SGL) that won the tender.

Today, the Integrated GIS and Image Processing Software (IGIS)—India's first-ever integrated GIS and image processing software—is being used by many government departments, including revenue, forests, power (the software can precisely detect the points where power is being stolen from transmission lines) and urban development.

As Nair remarked: “IGIS is unique as it can help analyse and process data from Indian as well as foreign satellites and aircraft. It can revolutionise application of space and GIS data for national purposes. It also ends India's dependence on foreign countries.” The SGL team, including its Technology Director Chirag Soni, worked for seven years in partnership with ISRO before coming up with their software solution. Sojitra, the son of a middle-level farmer, says: “We took it up as a mission for the nation and that is why we succeeded.” IGIS is superior to foreign software and cheaper. Imported ones cost around Rs 25 lakh, have a separate GIS and image processing system while IGIS is a combination of both and costs about Rs 12 lakh. One more home-grown feather in the Indian IT cap. ■